

A2-B1 · MAYA & EMMA ENGLISH

5 Evening Habits for a Better Tomorrow

Do your mornings feel fast and stressful? A good morning starts the evening before. Maya and Emma share five small evening habits, a speaking practice and a quick quiz.

Words in this episode

habit	something you do often, almost without thinking	*Reading before bed is a good habit.*
alarm	a sound that wakes you up	*My alarm rings at six o'clock.*
rush	to do things very fast because you have little time	*I was in a rush this morning.*
decision	a choice that you make	*What to wear is a small decision.*
energy	the power to do things without feeling tired	*I have more energy after a good sleep.*
prepare	to make something ready	*I prepare my bag in the evening.*
relax	to rest and feel calm	*I relax with a cup of tea.*
scroll	to move up and down on a screen	*I scroll on my phone too much.*
awake	not sleeping	*The bright screen keeps me awake.*
calm	quiet and peaceful, not excited	*I feel calm after a warm shower.*
stretch	to make your arms, legs or back long	*I stretch my back before bed.*
schedule	a plan that says when you do things	*I have a busy schedule this week.*

bedtime	the time when you usually go to bed	*My bedtime is eleven o'clock.*
routine	the things you do in the same order every day	*My evening routine is short and easy.*

Say it out loud

1. I was in a rush this morning.
2. I prepare my bag in the evening.
3. The bright screen keeps me awake.
4. I stretch my back before bed.
5. My evening routine is short and easy.
6. And now, the quiz. I will give you a meaning. You say the word. Then Maya will tell you the answer. Let's go. Question one. Which word means, a sound that wakes you up?
7. Question two. Which word means, to make something ready?
8. Question three. Which word means, not sleeping?
9. And question four. Which word means, the things you do in the same order every day?

Transcript

Welcome

Emma: Hello everyone, and welcome back to our podcast! I'm Emma. This is the place where you can learn English with slow and clear conversations. Today we will talk about something from daily life. We will talk about your evening. What do you do in the last hour before you sleep?

Maya: Hi Emma, and hi everyone! I'm Maya. Oh, that is a dangerous question for me. Most evenings, I lie on the sofa with my phone. Then I look at the clock, and it is midnight. And the next morning is terrible.

Emma: You are not alone, Maya. Many people think that a good day starts in the morning. But I think a good day starts the evening before. So today, we will share five small evening habits. They are easy, and they can make tomorrow much better.

Maya: And please stay with us until the end. We have a speaking practice and a small quiz for you. Okay, Emma. Let's begin.

Maya's terrible morning

Emma: Maya, before the habits, I want to hear a story. Tell us about a bad morning.

Maya: Oh, I have a good one. It was last Monday. The night before, I watched videos until one o'clock. In the morning, my alarm rang three times, but I didn't hear it. I woke up forty minutes late.

Emma: Oh no. Forty minutes is a lot. What happened next?

Maya: I jumped out of bed. I couldn't find a clean shirt. I couldn't find my keys. My phone had only five percent of battery. I had no time for breakfast, so I ran to the bus stop with wet hair and one black sock and one blue sock.

Emma: One black and one blue! Did you catch the bus?

Maya: No. I missed it. I was late for work, I was hungry, and I felt stressed all day. And here is the funny thing. Nothing really bad happened that morning. I was just in a rush from the first minute.

Emma: I know that feeling. When the morning is a rush, the whole day feels fast and heavy. But listen, Maya. Your bad morning didn't start at seven o'clock. It started the night before, on the sofa.

Maya: I know, I know. The sofa and the phone. That is where my Monday went wrong.

Why the evening matters

Maya: So, Emma, why is the evening so important? Why not just wake up earlier?

Emma: Good question. In the morning, your brain is still slow. You have little time, and you need to make many small decisions. What do I wear? What do I eat? Where is my bag? Each small decision takes a little energy.

Maya: That is true. In the morning, even a small question feels big. Black socks or blue socks? I can't answer that at seven o'clock.

Emma: Right. But in the evening, you have more time, and nobody is waiting for you. So you can make those decisions slowly. Then in the morning, you don't need to think. You just follow the plan.

Maya: So I do the thinking in the evening, and the doing in the morning.

Emma: Exactly. And there is one more reason. The evening decides how well you sleep. If your evening is loud and bright, your sleep is short and light. If your evening is calm, you sleep deeply, and you wake up with more energy.

Maya: Okay. I'm ready to change. Give me habit number one.

Habit 1: Get ready for tomorrow

Emma: Habit number one. Prepare your things for tomorrow. Do it before you sit down on the sofa.

Maya: What things do you mean?

Emma: Simple things. Choose your clothes, and put them on a chair. Put your keys, your wallet and your bag next to the door. If you take lunch to work, put it in a box in the fridge. And put your phone on the charger.

Maya: That sounds like my mother, Emma. She always said, prepare your school bag before you sleep.

Emma: Your mother was right! It takes only five minutes in the evening. But in the morning, it saves you fifteen minutes, and it saves you a lot of stress.

Maya: I tried this on Tuesday, after my terrible Monday. I put my clothes on a chair, with two black socks. In the morning, I didn't need to think. I just got dressed, took my bag, and left. It felt strange. It was too easy.

Emma: That is the feeling we want. An easy morning is not lucky. It is prepared.

Maya: I like that sentence. An easy morning is prepared.

Habit 2: Write three things

Maya: Okay, I think habit number two is mine. Write down three things that you want to do tomorrow. Only three.

Emma: Why do you write them in the evening, and not in the morning?

Maya: Because at night, my head is full. When I lie in bed, I think, I must call the bank. I must buy milk. I must send that email. The thoughts go round and round, and I can't sleep.

Emma: Oh yes. I call that the night radio. It plays the same songs again and again.

Maya: The night radio! That is a good name. So now, before I go to bed, I take a small piece of paper. I write three things for tomorrow. Then my brain can relax, because the paper remembers for me.

Emma: And why only three things? I usually have twenty things to do.

Maya: Me too. But a list of twenty things makes me tired before I start. So I choose the three most important things. If I finish them, it is a good day. Anything more is a present.

Emma: That is smart. Three important things, on paper, before bed. And in the morning, you already know where to start.

Habit 3: Put your phone to bed

Emma: Now, habit number three. I think this one is the hardest for you, Maya. Put your phone to bed before you go to bed.

Maya: Put my phone to bed? Does my phone need a pillow?

Emma: No pillow. But it needs its own place, and that place is not in your hand, and not next to your head. Thirty minutes before you sleep, put the phone on the charger, in another room or far from your bed.

Maya: Thirty minutes without my phone. Emma, that is very hard. I always say, just five more minutes. Then I scroll and scroll, and one hour is gone.

Emma: I know. The phone is made to keep you awake. The screen is bright, so your brain thinks it is still daytime. And every video gives you something new, so your brain doesn't want to stop.

Maya: That is true. After one hour of videos, my body is tired, but my head is wide awake.

Emma: So make it easy for yourself. Don't use the phone as your alarm. Buy a small, cheap clock, and put it next to your bed. Then the phone can sleep in the kitchen.

Maya: A real clock. Like my grandmother has. Okay, I will try it. But what do I do in those thirty minutes? I will be so bored.

Emma: That is a great question, because that is habit number four.

Habit 4: Do one calm thing

Emma: Habit number four. Do one calm thing before you sleep. It tells your body, the day is finished.

Maya: What kind of calm thing?

Emma: You can choose. For example, read a few pages of a book. Take a warm shower. Drink a cup of tea without sugar. Listen to quiet music. Or stretch your body for five minutes.

Maya: I like to stretch. I'm a cat, so I'm very good at it. I stretch my back, my legs, and my arms. It feels wonderful.

Emma: Then that is your calm thing. Mine is reading. I read ten pages of an easy book every night. Sometimes I read in English, so I learn new words and I get sleepy at the same time.

Maya: Wait. English books make you sleepy? That is not a good thing to say on an English podcast, Emma.

Emma: No, no! I mean, a quiet story makes me sleepy, in any language. And here is an idea for our listeners. You can listen to an easy English podcast before bed, with your eyes closed. It is calm, and you learn something.

Maya: Maybe this podcast! But please, don't fall asleep before the quiz.

Habit 5: Go to bed at the same time

Maya: And now, the last habit. Habit number five. Go to bed at the same time every night.

Emma: Yes. This one is simple to understand, but it is not so easy to do. Your body has a clock inside. It likes a schedule. When you sleep at eleven one night, and at two the next night, your body is confused.

Maya: Like when you fly to a different country. You feel tired at the wrong time.

Emma: Exactly. But some people do that to themselves every weekend, without a plane. So choose a bedtime that is good for you, and try to keep it. For most adults, seven or eight hours of sleep is good.

Maya: How do I remember my bedtime? In the evening, I always forget the time.

Emma: Here is a small trick. Don't only set an alarm for the morning. Set an alarm for the evening too. When it rings, it says, Maya, start to get ready for bed.

Maya: An alarm to go to sleep. I never thought of that. I will give it a nice sound, not an angry sound.

Emma: Good idea. A soft sound. And when you hear it, you start your little evening routine. Prepare your things, write three things, put the phone to bed, and do one calm thing.

Three common mistakes

Emma: Now let's talk about three common mistakes. Mistake number one. Starting all five habits on the same day.

Maya: Oh, I do that. I get excited, and I want to change my whole life on Monday. On Wednesday I'm tired, and on Friday I stop everything.

Emma: Right. It is too much. Choose only one habit, and do it for one week. When it feels easy, add the next one. Slow is okay. Slow is how habits stay.

Maya: Mistake number two. Coffee or strong tea late in the afternoon. I love coffee, but it stays in the body for many hours. If I drink a coffee at five o'clock, I'm still awake at midnight.

Emma: Yes. For most people, it is better to stop coffee after lunch. In the evening, drink water or a tea without caffeine.

Maya: And mistake number three. Being angry at yourself after one bad night. Sometimes you have a party, or a lot of work, or a baby who cries. You go to bed late. That is life.

Emma: That is very important. One bad night doesn't break your routine. Just start again the next evening. Don't say, I failed. Say, I will try again tonight.

Your plan for tonight

Emma: So, Maya. Let's make a small plan for tonight. I want our listeners to make one too. What is your bedtime?

Maya: Let me think. I wake up at seven. So my bedtime is eleven o'clock.

Emma: Good. So at ten o'clock, your soft alarm rings. What do you do first?

Maya: First, I prepare my clothes and my bag. That takes five minutes. Then I write my three things for tomorrow. At half past ten, I put my phone on the charger in the kitchen. I say, good night, phone.

Emma: Very polite. And then?

Maya: Then I stretch like a happy cat, and I read a few pages. At eleven, I turn off the light.

Emma: That is a lovely plan. It takes less than one hour, and most of it is calm. Now, dear listeners, it's your turn. What is your bedtime? Which habit will you start with tonight? Choose only one.

Your turn: speaking practice

Maya: Okay, everyone. Now it's your turn to speak. Emma will say a sentence with one of today's words. After that, there is a short quiet time. Please say the sentence out loud. Are you ready? Here is sentence number one.

Emma: I was in a rush this morning.

Maya: Very good. Here is sentence number two.

Emma: I prepare my bag in the evening.

Maya: Nice. Here is sentence number three.

Emma: The bright screen keeps me awake.

Maya: Great job. Here is sentence number four.

Emma: I stretch my back before bed.

Maya: And here is the last one. Sentence number five.

Emma: My evening routine is short and easy.

Maya: Well done! You just used five words from this episode. Say them again tonight, before you sleep.

Quick quiz

Emma: And now, the quiz. I will give you a meaning. You say the word. Then Maya will tell you the answer. Let's go. Question one. Which word means, a sound that wakes you up?

Maya: The answer is, alarm. My alarm rings at six o'clock.

Emma: Question two. Which word means, to make something ready?

Maya: The answer is, prepare. I prepare my bag in the evening.

Emma: Question three. Which word means, not sleeping?

Maya: The answer is, awake. The bright screen keeps me awake.

Emma: And question four. Which word means, the things you do in the same order every day?

Maya: The answer is, routine. And now you have a new evening routine!

Emma: How many answers did you know? If you knew two or more, that is a great start. Listen to this episode again tomorrow evening, and try the quiz one more time.

Review and goodbye

Maya: Let's quickly review our five evening habits. Habit one. Prepare your things for tomorrow. Habit two. Write down three important things. Habit three. Put your phone to bed, thirty minutes before you sleep.

Emma: Habit four. Do one calm thing, like reading or stretching. And habit five. Go to bed at the same time every night. Start with only one habit, and add the next one slowly.

Maya: And remember, an easy morning is not lucky. It is prepared. I learned that after one black sock and one blue sock.

Emma: We have a small job for you today. Tell us in the comments. What time is your bedtime? And which habit will you try tonight? We would love to read your answers.

Maya: If this episode helped you, please like the video and subscribe to our channel. And share it with a friend who is always tired in the morning.

Emma: Thank you for listening, everyone. Have a calm evening, and a wonderful tomorrow. See you in the next episode!

Maya: Good night, everyone. Sleep well!